

Nature travels

In 1799, German naturalist Alexander von Humboldt set out to explore the rivers and mountains of South America, from Venezuela to Ecuador and Peru. He traveled more than 6,000 miles (9,600 km), collected thousands of natural specimens, climbed a volcano, and even described a fight with an electric eel. He studied the interactions between geology, climate, and the distribution of plants and animals, and is regarded as the founder of ecology, the study of the relationship between living organisms and their environment.

